

Band of BROTHERS

From being small-time businessmen 10 years ago, the Reddys are now worth hundreds of crores

In Andhra Pradesh, they are called the Gali brothers; in neighbouring Karnataka, the Telugu-speaking mine barons are called the Gali Reddy brothers. Ten years ago, Gali Janardhan Reddy and his siblings were small-time businessmen in Bellary. The other members of the political family are Revenue Minister G. Karunakara Reddy, Bellary MLA Gali Somashekhara Reddy and a family friend they treat as a brother, Health Minister B. Sriramulu.

It was Janardhan who first spotted a business opportunity in the mining industry. Gradually, they became close to the late Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy, who helped Janardhan launch a steel plant in Kadapa, YSR's home district. Between them, the Reddys now own a slew of imported cars, two Bell helicopters and a custom-built minibus for commuting in Bellary and the surrounding region. The minibus alone costs a whopping Rs 4 crore.

Their muscle is drawn from bankrolling more than 20 MLAs in at least six north Karnataka districts. It is not just their financial resources that help them string the MLAs together but their sheer gall to rally all the Yeddyurappa-baiters to their side even if it is, as the Reddys claim, in the interest of the BJP in Karnataka. A few months ago, the deeply religious Reddy brothers made news when they donated a Rs 45-crore, 30-kg diamond-studded crown to the Balaji Temple in Tirupati.

Sons of a police constable, the Reddys had also launched a

Rs 25-crore drinking water supply project in their mother's name. In starting a Rs 500-crore private project to build 54,000 houses for flood-hit villages in six districts, the Reddy's sole aim was to increase their hold on a region beyond Bellary, Karnataka's mining capital.



JANARDHAN (LEFT) WANTS KARANDLAJE (RIGHT) OUT OF THE CABINET

The Reddys, who have no RSS training, also missed the BJP's three chintan baithaks. There is also some talk of them floating a regional party if they feel that the high command is letting them down. Some Congress leaders will be pleased if Karnataka Governor H.R. Bhardwaj, a former law minister, gets into the thick of the action if the Reddys don't blink.

district, rattling a few BJP old-timers like MLA S.A. Ramdas, who was placated by being made parliamentary secretary to the chief minister. But after Karandlaje sidelined Ramdas, he switched to the Reddy camp.

The turning point in her political career was 2004, the year she became an MLC. It was also the same year when Yeddyurappa's wife Maitradevi was found dead in a water tank in their Shimoga house. Yeddyurappa was leader of the Opposition then. While the police treated it as an unnatural death, some of his detractors asked for investigations into her

death. Shimoga Additional SP D.C. Rajappa was one of the visitors who paid homage to Yeddyurappa just after his wife's death. He is the same Rajappa that Yeddyurappa transferred to Bellary in his infamous bout of anger on October 28, 2009, the day the Reddy brothers and other mining barons were launching their own initiative to build 54,000 houses for the flood-hit people in Bellary and other